

Maria Silva

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LLB and LLM graduate with practical experience in case preparation, procedural document drafting, statutory analysis and client-facing advice across disputes, welfare and regulatory matters. Currently advising clients at Citizens Advice on housing, benefits and employment issues, applying statutory and evidential frameworks to complex facts. Previous experience at BCLP includes a year supporting international arbitration and real estate disputes, with responsibility for hearing bundles, procedural submissions, evidence review and deadline management across multiple matters. Strong legal research, written communication and case-file management skills, with an interest in public law, regulatory proceedings and public protection.

EDUCATION

LLM Comparative and International Dispute Resolution — Merit Sept 2024 – Oct 2025

Queen Mary University of London

- Modules in international arbitration, dispute resolution procedure, legal research and evidence analysis
- Transnational Law and Governance Applied module (covering data privacy and democratic governance) — 75%
- Dissertation: data protection and the development of GDPR across jurisdictions

LLB Law — 2:1 Sept 2020 – June 2024

University College London

- Modules included Alternative Dispute Resolution, Advanced Contract Law, Commercial Law and Company Law

International Foundation Programme in Law and International Relations Sept 2019 – June 2020

King's College London

- Awarded the Leaders of Tomorrow prize (top 20 of a 200-student cohort; partial funding toward undergraduate degree)

EXPERIENCE

Citizens Advice East Berkshire · Maidenhead July 2026 – Present

Legal Adviser

- Advises clients across welfare benefits, employment, housing, family, debt and consumer matters; takes detailed factual statements, establishes chronologies and identifies relevant legal and evidential issues
- Assesses eligibility for Universal Credit, Housing Benefit and related support against statutory and regulatory criteria; identifies evidential gaps and researches complex points of law
- Manages matters from instruction through to submission: drafts correspondence, prepares applications and document schedules, maintains confidential case records and meets deadlines
- Translates complex statutory requirements into clear, practical guidance for vulnerable individuals; advises on procedural options and next steps

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Legal Placement Student — International Arbitration

- Supported a complex investment arbitration: reviewed and organised evidence for procedural submissions and the Claimant's memorial; drafted procedural orders and procedural histories
- Became the only junior supporting the team shortly before a significant submission deadline; coordinated documents, tracked outstanding actions and helped ensure on-time delivery
- Liaised with the client on required documents; coordinated Romanian translations with an external translator
- Maintained structured electronic case files and monitored procedural deadlines throughout the matter

- Received feedback from a partner and associate that performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London

Aug 2023 – Feb 2024

Legal Placement Student — Real Estate Disputes

- Supported hearing preparation: reviewed documents, prepared electronic bundles and assisted with skeleton arguments and court materials
- Conducted legal and factual research on rights of light, easements, leasehold issues and landlord and tenant disputes
- Prepared client notes; maintained matter records via iManage; assisted with court filings and hearing arrangements
- Managed large volumes of confidential documents across several matters with competing deadlines; tracked costs and assisted with matter opening and closure

Q-Legal · London

Oct 2024 – Jan 2025

Legal Adviser

- Managed a data-privacy matter from client instruction through to formal written advice, under a qualified solicitor's supervision
- Researched UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 obligations for a data-driven start-up, including children's personal data and adtech
- Identified compliance risks from the client's data processing and recommended practical mitigations in commercially focused written advice

Adobe · London

June 2022 – Aug 2022

Legal Intern

- Reviewed and amended software licensing agreements; identified contractual risks and assessed alignment with internal legal and compliance requirements
- Reviewed data-processing and confidentiality provisions; researched UK GDPR, EU GDPR and cross-border personal data transfer rules
- Liaised with sales, legal and international business teams to resolve contractual queries; communicated amendments to stakeholders
- Prepared and delivered an internal presentation on breach-of-contract risks and mitigation measures

SKILLS

Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Technical skills: Legal and commercial research; statutory analysis; documentary analysis; concise report and correspondence drafting; Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint; iManage; legal research databases; electronic court filing portals; document review; electronic bundling; case management and time-recording systems

Case and evidence management: Evidence review, hearing bundle preparation, procedural histories, case-file organisation, deadline tracking across multiple concurrent matters